

E3 Empowerment Through Delegation

Pillar	Enablement	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	40-50 minutes	Group Size	Manager solo or 1:1
Mode	Manager self-work (with team input)	Format	Any
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Micromanagement signals, empowerment gaps, manager bottleneck indicators, team members not taking initiative, decision-making delays

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Delegation is a dopamine transaction. When a manager delegates meaningfully (not just dumping tasks), the recipient's brain registers autonomy, which activates intrinsic motivation circuitry. Research by Deci and Ryan (Self-Determination Theory) shows that autonomy is one of three core psychological needs; when met, it produces sustained engagement. When denied, it produces compliance at best and resentment at worst.

For the manager, poor delegation creates a cortisol trap. Holding onto too much work sustains chronic stress, which progressively impairs the very judgment needed to decide what to keep and what to let go. The manager who says 'it's faster if I do it myself' is describing a cortisol-driven decision, not an accurate assessment of team capability.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Delegation Audit (15 minutes)

The manager lists every recurring task and decision they currently handle. For each one, categorise:

Category	Description	Examples	Action
Only I can do this	Requires my authority, access, or expertise that genuinely cannot be shared	Final budget approval, performance reviews, confidential HR matters	Keep
I do this but shouldn't	Someone else could do this with training or authority transfer	Report formatting, meeting scheduling, first-pass data reviews, routine approvals	Delegate

I do this because it's faster	Short-term faster, long-term bottleneck. Someone else could learn.	Client communications, process decisions, troubleshooting	Invest in delegation (train, then transfer)
Nobody should do this	This task could be automated, eliminated, or simplified	Redundant reports, unnecessary approval steps, legacy processes	Eliminate (connect to E9)

Phase 2: The Skill-Will Matrix (10 minutes)

For each task in the 'delegate' and 'invest' categories, assess who could take it on using two dimensions:

- Skill: does this person have (or could they quickly develop) the capability? (Low / Medium / High)
- Will: does this person want this responsibility? (Low / Medium / High)

The ideal delegation target is high-skill, high-will. High-skill, low-will needs a conversation about motivation. Low-skill, high-will needs training investment. Low-skill, low-will is not a delegation candidate.

Phase 3: The Delegation Conversation (15 minutes per delegation)

For each planned delegation, have a 1:1 conversation with the recipient using this structure:

1. Context: why you're delegating this (not "I'm too busy" but "I think you're ready for this and it will develop your [skill]")
2. Scope: exactly what is being delegated, including decision authority
3. Support: what help is available (training, check-ins, who to go to with questions)
4. Expectations: what success looks like and what the reporting/update cadence is
5. Safety: what happens if it doesn't go perfectly (connect to V7's safe-to-fail framework)

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm handing this to you because I trust you to handle it, not because I'm dumping work. Here's what you need to know, here's the authority you have, and here's where I'm available if you need me. I'm going to resist the urge to check in constantly. If you need me, come to me. Otherwise, it's yours."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The manager's 'only I can do this' list is suspiciously long	Challenge honestly: "For each item on this list, ask: is it truly that only I can do this, or that I haven't invested in preparing someone else to do it?" The distinction between 'only I can' and 'only I currently do' is

	where most delegation opportunities hide.
The manager delegates but then micromanages the execution	This is the most common delegation failure. Build a specific check-in cadence into the delegation and then stick to it. "We agreed to a weekly update. Between updates, I trust you to handle it." If the manager finds themselves checking in daily, the issue is the manager's anxiety, not the delegate's capability.
A delegated task fails or produces poor results	Do not take it back. Debrief: "What happened? What would you do differently? What support would have helped?" Taking a task back after the first difficulty teaches the team that delegation is temporary and conditional.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
OP11: Project Ownership	E3 provides the delegation skill. OP11 provides the ownership transfer structure. They work as a pair.	Complementary
E6: Decision-Making Autonomy	Delegation without decision authority is just task assignment. E6 provides the autonomy framework E3 needs.	Run E3 and E6 together
V7: Reducing Fear of Failure	Delegation requires safe-to-fail conditions. V7 establishes them.	V7 before E3 for risk-averse managers
E9: Removing Outdated Processes	The 'nobody should do this' category from E3's audit feeds directly into E9.	E3 feeds into E9